

BLIND ENGINEERING An aerial view of the newly built bridge with a 90-degree turn in Bhopal's Aishbagh area, Jun. 12

ANI

Takeaways

- **Infamy chases 'Ninety Degrees Bridge' in Bhopal, Z-shaped flyover in Indore**
- **A rattled PWD first orders suspension of work on 355 flyovers and railway overbridges, but retracts later**
- **A design review is on. Minister feels PWD itself needs one, sets ball rolling**

MADHYA PRADESH

90 DEGREES OF REPARATION

The public works wing gets a public hanging, but MP's jagged flyovers are only symptoms of a systemic skew

By **Rahul Noronha**

FOR A FEW WEEKS NOW, Bhopal has been famous on social media for a flyover in the city's Aishbagh area: local wits have dubbed it the 'Ninety Degree Bridge', owing to a sharp turn it takes in mid-flight. Public censure effectively grounded seven engineers, including two chief engineers, of the Public Works Department (PWD). As the negative portrayals of the department piled up, with incompetence and dishonesty becoming buzzwords, the state government was forced to order a probe and eventually suspend the said officials.

Not many days had passed when another flyover, this time in Indore, was dubbed the 'Z-Shaped Flyover' and declared an engineering disaster. A rattled PWD first ordered suspension of work on all 355 flyovers and railway overbridges, pending a review of their designs, and then retracted. But the nervousness showed. Vast sums of public money seemed to be going down the drain due to engineers who didn't know their work—and the absence of an oversight system. Suddenly, it seemed the PWD, itself a creaking edifice of Raj vintage and a veteran of miles of bridges and roads over the decades, just couldn't get anything right.

So, what ails the state PWD? Not funds. With an outlay of Rs 14,000 crore this year, it's one of the few departments that managed to corner a goodish share of the budget—remember, MP is a state where Ladli Behna payoffs take an annual toll of around